

The Formation of a Reaction

Best done near the end of the week, when you've had time to catch a triggered moment or two in real life. You'll be mapping one of your own sankharas end to end, the same way Paul's calendar invite was mapped in this week's lesson. Plan on 45 to 60 minutes. Keep what you write. You'll bring a piece of it to your Integration and Next-Step Session.

This journal walks you through the five steps of a triggered moment in your own life. The goal isn't to solve the loop yet. It's to see it. Once you can see where you are at each stage, you can start to notice where the opening is.

A note on what to pick. If you filled in the first journal this week, the thing you named there is usually held in place by one of these loops, and a moment when it fired is a good one to map. Or pick any recent moment of being triggered that's still close to the surface. Either works.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Take a few minutes of breath first. Sit with your eyes closed. Let your body settle. When you feel you've arrived, open your eyes and begin writing.

1. THE TRIGGER (CONTACT)

Bring to mind a recent moment when something triggered you. A conversation. An email. A look. A silence. A meeting on your calendar. A bill in the mail.

Describe the moment as it actually happened. What was the situation? What was the trigger?

2. THE BODY'S FIRST RESPONSE (FEELING TONE)

Bring the memory of that moment back to mind. Hold it there. Don't try to relive it. Just let the picture be present.

Now notice what's happening in your body *right now*, as you sit here holding the memory. The pattern that fired then is firing now. Same system, same groove. The body holds the pattern, and the memory wakes it up.

Where in your body do you feel something? Tightness, heat, heaviness, sinking, contraction, nausea, throbbing, pulse? Describe the sensation as it's present right now, not what you remember it being then.

Paul's toes curl. What's yours, right now?

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3. THE STORY YOUR MIND IS TELLING (STORY)

Stay with the memory and the sensation in your body. Now notice what your mind is doing.

What story is it telling? It might be the same one from the original moment. It might be a new spin on the same theme. It might be a story about what you should be doing instead of writing this journal. Whatever it is, it's running right now.

Paul's mind said *I'm being laid off*. What's yours saying, right now? Quote it as you actually hear it.

4. THE REACTION (REACTION)

Two parts to this prompt.

What you did then. In the original moment, you acted. Did you go into aversion (numb out, withdraw, doom-scroll, escape, hide, shut down)? Or into craving (grab, push, fix, chase, perform, work harder, prove)? Or a mix? Describe the reaction. What did you do?

What you want to do now. As you sit here, holding the memory and feeling whatever's alive in your body, what does the system want to do *in this moment*? What's the pull? Close the journal and walk away? Check your phone? Eat something? Make a list? Lie down? Refresh your email? Find a project to dive into?

The pull right now is the same pull that fired then. The original moment is gone. The pattern is alive in real time.

5. THE MENTAL SPINNING (SPINNING)

After the reaction came, what did the mind do?

Rumination. Replay. Worst-case scenarios. Shame. Blame. Trying to figure out why this happened. Trying to figure out who's at fault. Imagining the future. Rewriting the past.

Describe the spiral. How long did it last? What did it cost you in time, energy, or sleep?

6. WHERE THE OPENING WAS

Look back at your own five steps. Where was the razor-thin space between the trigger and the switch?

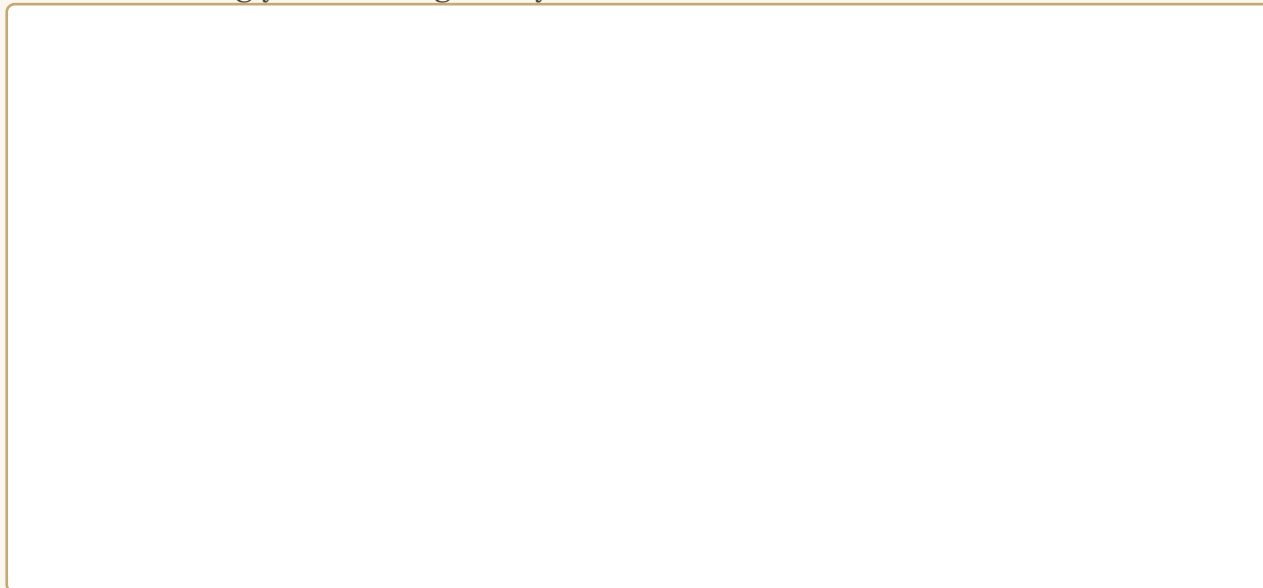
Most likely, the opening was at the feeling tone, before the story arrived. What was happening in your body for a beat, sometimes a long beat, before the story took over?

Write what you can see now that you couldn't see in the moment.

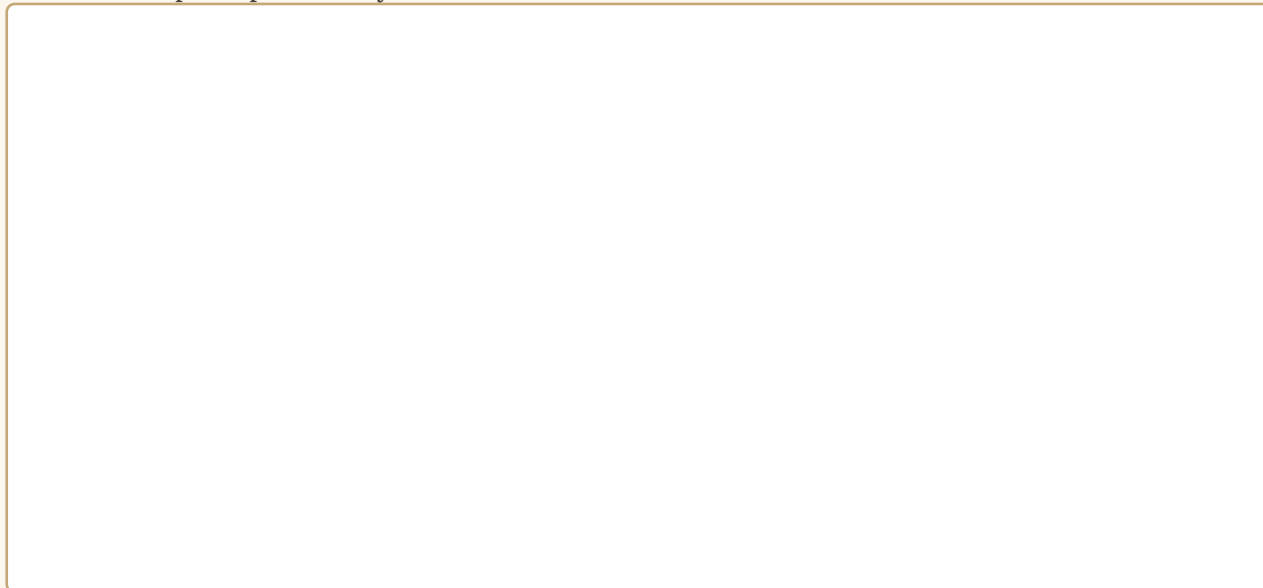
CLOSING THE WEEK

Two questions I ask at the end of every session.

What's one thing you're taking with you from this week?

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What's an open question you're left with?

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